WASHINGTON, DC, UNITED STATES

The Phillips Collection: Masterpieces

Twenty works gather diners, travellers, performers and neighbours, with quieter intervals between them.



Renoir's boating party contains several conversations, not one event commanding everyone at the table. That dispersed attention is worth carrying into the other pictures here. Daumier's sculptors concentrate on a shared object; Lawrence's travellers move towards named destinations; a clown prepares for an audience that is not yet present. The reasons people gather are different, and the paintings make those differences visible. Between these groups, landscapes and still lifes change the pace. A candle, river ice or a palm frond can organise a picture without a human exchange at its centre. This selection follows such shifts across works in Washington's Phillips Collection.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/phillips-collection

The selection · 20

1. Luncheon of the Boating Party
   Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1880-1881
2. The Migration Series, Panel 1
   Jacob Lawrence · 1940–1941
3. The Palm
   Pierre Bonnard · 1926
4. The Spanish Ballet
   Édouard Manet · 1862
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   Chaim Soutine · c. 1937
6. The Pink Candle
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7. The Goatherd of Genzano
   Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot · 1843
8. Two Sculptors
   Honoré Daumier · 1870-1873
9. Footsteps
   Kenzo Okada · 1954
10. Self-Portrait
    Piet Mondrian · c. 1900
11. Clown Making Up
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12. Moonlit Cove
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16. The Tambourine
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Luncheon of the Boating Party

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1880-1881 · The Phillips Collection



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. The Luncheon of the Boating Party. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Bottles, glasses and fruit fill a table around which attention travels in several directions. Renoir connects the diners through overlapping bodies and glances without making them respond to the same incident. The awning gathers their different conversations under one cover. Apparent informality depends on this firm arrangement: the group can remain coherent while individual people drink, talk or attend to someone outside the nearest exchange.

Object source · Open artwork

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The Migration Series, Panel 1

Jacob Lawrence

1940–1941 · The Phillips Collection



Jacob Lawrence. The Migration of the Negro, Panel 1. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Chicago, New York and St. Louis appear above a crowd pressing towards departure. The signs give direction to bodies simplified into dark shapes and bright clothing. Lawrence opens his sixty-panel account of African American migration from the South with collective movement, rather than the biography of one traveller. The named cities make this more than a general image of a crowd: geography becomes part of its organisation.

Object source · Open artwork

03 / 20

The Palm

Pierre Bonnard

1926 · Oil on canvas · The Phillips Collection



Pierre Bonnard. The Palm. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/pierre-bonnard/the-palm-1926 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Spreading fronds interrupt a view of buildings and vegetation. Bonnard lets the near plant take up space that a more orderly landscape might leave open for distant scenery. Colour overlaps rather than dividing the view into clean stages, and the small foreground figure gives only a partial measure of scale. Finding distance here means working around the palm, not looking through a convenient gap left for us.

Object source · Open artwork

04 / 20

The Spanish Ballet

Édouard Manet

1862 · Oil on canvas · The Phillips Collection



Édouard Manet. The spanish ballet. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/edouard-manet/the-spanish-ballet-1862 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Pale skirts catch the light among costumed performers in a dim setting. Their different poses retain suggestions of movement without combining into a single dance step. Manet brings the company together through those scattered light areas, allowing individuals to remain separate within a public identity. The performance is present in costume and posture even where the group appears momentarily suspended between actions.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Woman in Profile: Madame Tennent

Chaim Soutine

c. 1937 · Oil on canvas · The Phillips Collection



Chaim Soutine. Woman in Profile (Portrait of Madame Tennent). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/chaim-soutine/woman-in-profile-portrait-of-madame-tennent · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The sharp turn of the head gives this portrait its immediate direction. Warm patches describe the face against dark clothes and a roughly handled background. Soutine's uneven surface does not dissolve the sitter into paint: the profile remains specific enough to hold its place. The comparison is between a recognisable pose and marks that refuse the smoothness we might expect from a finished likeness.

Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Pink Candle

Henri Rousseau

1909-1910 · The Phillips Collection



Henri Rousseau. The Pink Candle. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

A candle, bottle, plate and fruit occupy a shallow setting, each object held by a firm outline. Rousseau makes them easy to identify but harder to place in a smoothly measurable space. Their separateness matters as much as the arrangement they form together. The plain background leaves little else to consider, so differences of height, colour and boundary give modest household things an unusually insistent presence.

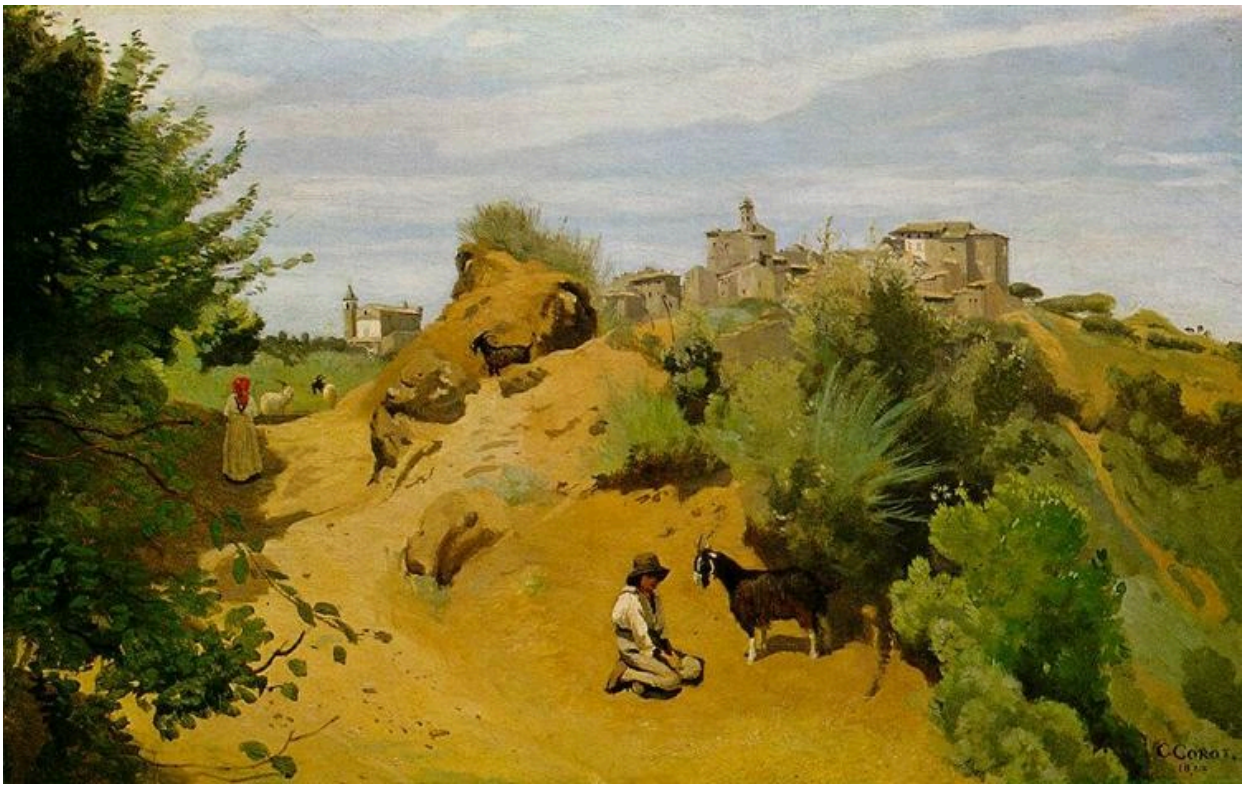
Object source · Open artwork

07 / 20

The Goatherd of Genzano

Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot

1843 · The Phillips Collection



The goatherd of Genzano. WikiArt; Jean-Baptiste-Camille Corot. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The goatherd and animals establish a small, inhabited scale on the path below distant buildings. Corot's light connects the foreground to the town, while trees and rough ground frame the opening between them. No dramatic encounter is needed to explain why the figures belong here. Their ordinary passage helps join near and far, giving the landscape a use without turning it into the illustration of an incident.

Object source · Open artwork

08 / 20

Two Sculptors

Honoré Daumier

1870-1873 · The Phillips Collection



Honoré Daumier. Two Sculptors. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Two men incline towards a small sculpted form, their faces and the object emerging from a dark interior. Daumier makes their converging poses the clearest evidence of a shared task. They are looking rather than visibly working with tools, yet the attention is itself part of making. The sculpture occupies the space between them as something to judge, giving their proximity a practical reason.

Object source · Open artwork

09 / 20

Footsteps

Kenzo Okada

1954 · The Phillips Collection



Kenzo Okada. Footsteps. Image: WikiArt. Copyright protected (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Copyright protected (WikiArt label)

Scattered marks and subdued geometric areas occupy a pale field. Okada's title suggests passage through a place, though the surface supplies neither a continuous path nor a figure walking it. The intervals become important: a viewer can connect separated marks without finding a complete landscape. That bodily association is a possibility offered by the title, not a key that explains every shape.

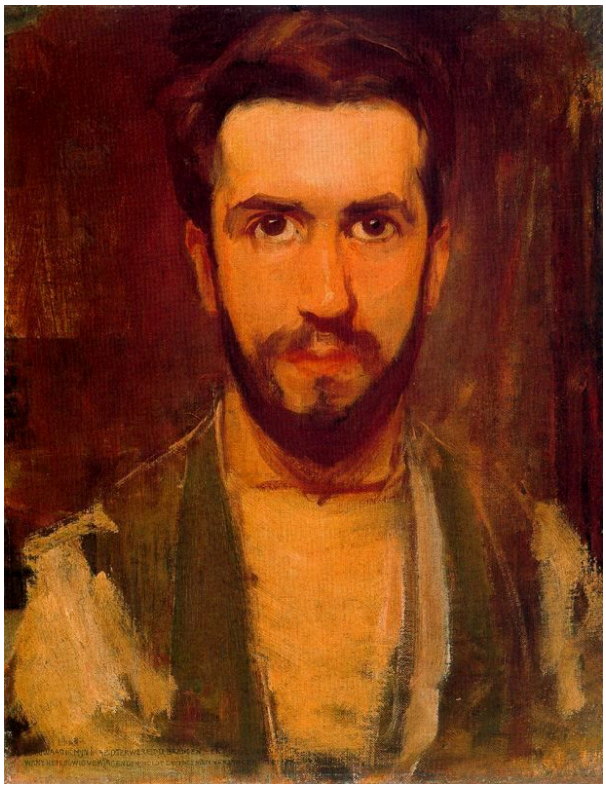
Object source · Open artwork

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Self-Portrait

Piet Mondrian

c. 1900 · Oil on canvas · The Phillips Collection



Piet Mondrian. Self Portrait. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/piet-mondrian/self-portrait-1900 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Mondrian's bearded face looks directly outward above an open collar, modelled in warm light against a dark reddish ground. This early painting need not be treated as a puzzle containing his later grids in disguise. Its decisions concern a particular face, tonal transitions and the encounter established by a gaze. Letting it remain a portrait makes the distance from his better-known abstraction clearer, not less interesting.

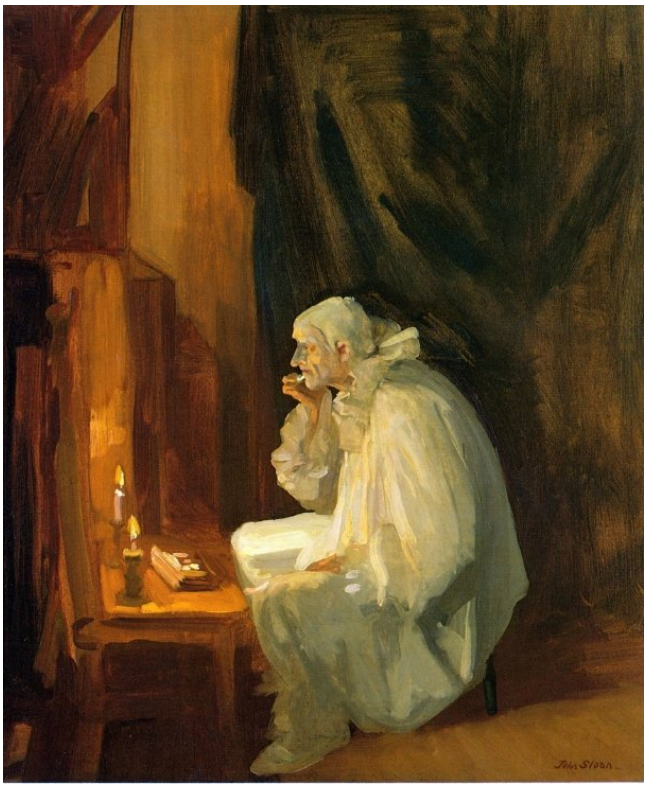
Object source · Open artwork

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Clown Making Up

John Sloan

1909 · Oil on canvas · The Phillips Collection



John Sloan. Clown Making Up. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/john-french-sloan/clown-making-up-1909 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

A performer sits at a small table beside curtains, with light concentrated on the face and preparations. Sloan places the clown before the public appearance, when costume and makeup are still things to be worked on. The figure's concentration belongs to that practical task rather than a joke. Separating preparation from performance allows the person doing the work to remain visible beneath the role.

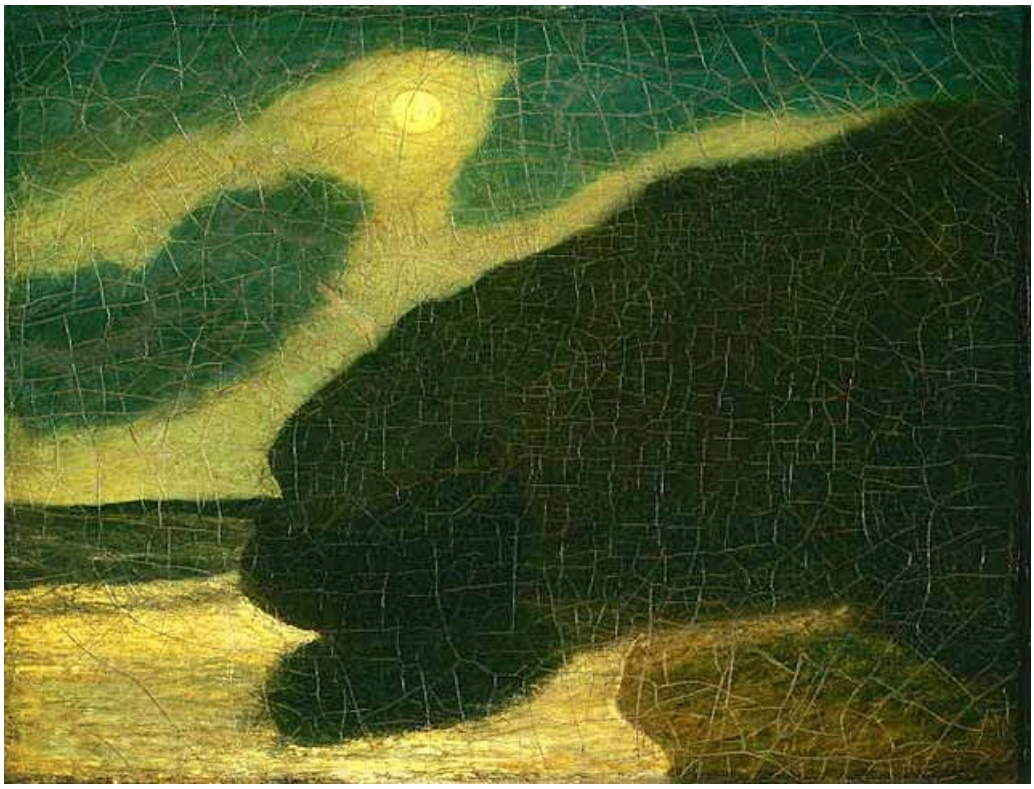
Object source · Open artwork

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Moonlit Cove

Albert Pinkham Ryder

1885 · The Phillips Collection



Albert Pinkham Ryder. Moonlit Cove. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The moon appears between long clouds, and its reflection marks a narrow opening through dark water. Ryder withholds the detailed coastline that might locate the cove precisely. Large dark masses give the small areas of light their force, making visibility itself the subject of comparison. The reflected path draws the eye without supplying a route anyone could actually follow across the water.

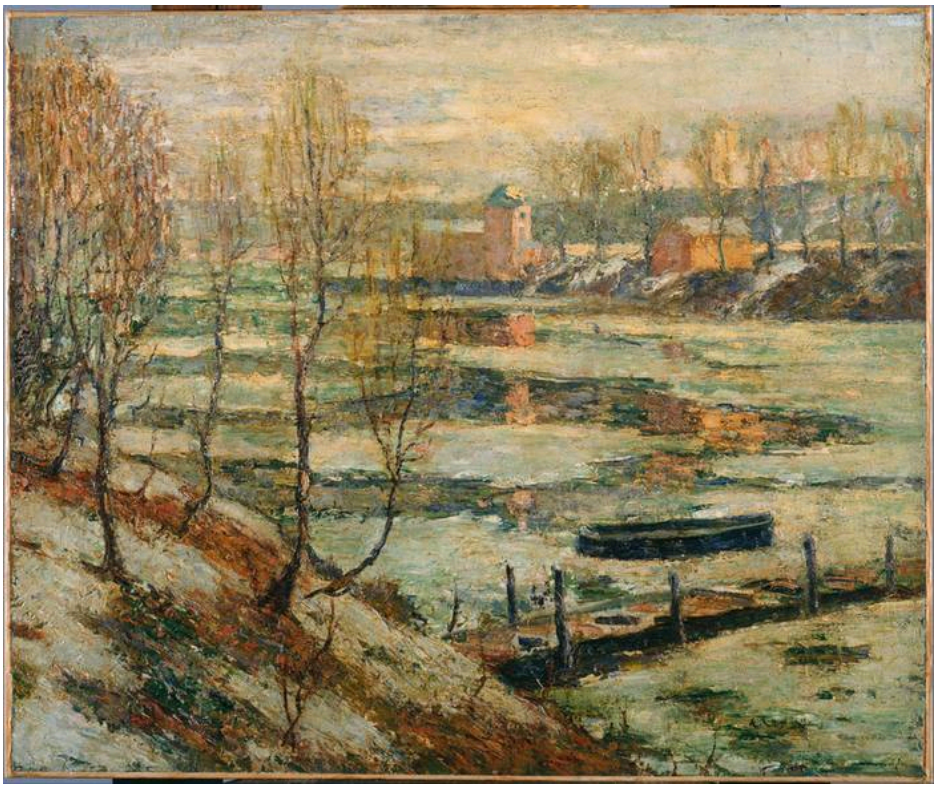
Object source · Open artwork

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Ice in the River

Ernest Lawson

c. 1907 · Oil on canvas mounted on wood panel · The Phillips Collection



Ernest Lawson. Ice in the River. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/ernest-lawson/ice-in-the-river-1907 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

Broken ice, water and winter banks share a close range of pale colours. Lawson's varied strokes distinguish their surfaces without separating them into sharply outlined compartments. Buildings beyond the river prevent the scene from becoming an uninhabited winter wilderness. The surface is changing within a place people use; the dark accents and scattered trees help measure that expanse of unstable, partly frozen water.

Object source · Open artwork

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Approaching Storm

Ernest Lawson

1919-1920 · The Phillips Collection



Ernest Lawson. Approaching Storm. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Dark clouds gather above hills, a house and water, but light still reaches sections of the ground. Lawson makes the unevenness of those conditions matter. A uniformly dark landscape would show less of the change announced by the title. Here the remaining bright passages give the approaching weather something to alter, letting one view contain both the present illumination and the threat to it.

Object source · Open artwork

15 / 20

Carcassonne

Walter Griffin

1911 · The Phillips Collection



Walter Griffin. Carcassonne. Image credit: Walter Griffin (1861 - 1935) (American) Details on Google Art Project; Source credit: ZgFuuMNTGlhcsw at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Fortified buildings rise beyond a tree-lined wall, yet Griffin does not reserve a separate, polished manner for the architecture. Broken colour describes stone, foliage and open ground alike. The town's recognisable outline survives within that shared handling. Its monumental character depends on its forms and position, while the active painted surface keeps it exposed to the same light as the less imposing growth nearby.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 0852

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The Tambourine

Jerome Myers

1905 · The Phillips Collection



Jerome Myers. The Tambourine. Image credit: Jerome Myers; Source credit: 7wHjwDKUfWrLaA at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Children gather beneath buildings and shopfronts that greatly exceed their scale. Pale dresses and small gestures separate them from darker walls. Myers makes the street both a built enclosure and a place temporarily occupied by play. The group is uneven, leaving room for individual movements; the architecture supplies a common measure without determining exactly how each child uses the space below it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1413

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Evening on the Pier

Jerome Myers

1921 · The Phillips Collection



Jerome Myers. Evening on the Pier. Image credit: Jerome Myers; Source credit: ZAEVkDDWFhD1mA at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

Women and children sit or stand close together beside the water, while distant structures stretch along the horizon. Myers gives their gathering several degrees of rest rather than one defining event. The open distance contrasts with the bodies' proximity. A public place becomes briefly particular through the ways people occupy it, and the warm evening light connects their separate positions without making them a single conversation.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1405

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The Evangelist

Robert Spencer

c. 1918 · The Phillips Collection



Robert Spencer. The Evangelist. Image credit: Robert Spencer; Source credit: fwHnMEF7DE48JQ at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

The speaker's raised position gives him a clear advantage in visibility over the street crowd. Below, differences in faces, hats and posture prevent the listeners from becoming one repeated shape. Spencer organises public address through unequal heights, but that arrangement cannot tell us that every person agrees or even listens in the same way. The gathering is visible; its collective response remains less certain.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1791

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The Auction

Robert Spencer

c. 1918 · The Phillips Collection



Robert Spencer. The Auction. Image credit: Robert Spencer; Source credit: bAHfxH45l2plVg at Google Cultural Institute maximum zoom level. Wikimedia Commons. Public domain (https://creativecommons.org/publicdomain/mark/1.0/). Resized and JPEG-compressed; selected source frame preserved. · Public domain

People cluster at an open doorway, their attention drawn towards objects and a raised figure. Pale walls and shutters give the gathering a firm architectural frame. Spencer turns a domestic threshold into a place of public valuation: looking and waiting become parts of an exchange. The crowd's shared direction is clear, even though the painting does not require us to know what each person would pay.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1790

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After the Ride

Julian Alden Weir

1903 · The Phillips Collection



Julian Alden Weir. After the Ride aka Visiting Neighbors. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

The saddled horse identifies an activity that has paused, while the woman stands beside it beneath trees. Its darker body gives her pale dress a clear neighbour. Weir distributes dappled light across figure and ground, keeping the portrait within its outdoor setting. The title supplies an earlier action, but the picture concentrates on the quieter arrangement left after movement has stopped.

Object source · Open artwork

Compare the reasons for gathering

Renoir's diners, Daumier's sculptors and Spencer's auction crowd all share a space, but they share attention differently. Returning to those differences is more useful than treating every group as a picture of sociability. This independent selection does not promise that the works are displayed together or currently available to view. Consult the collection's current records when planning a visit.

Further reading

Impressionism: A Centenary Exhibition

Anne Dayez, Michel Hoog and Charles S. Moffett · Read online or download · English

The Metropolitan Museum’s catalogue provides historical context for Renoir and Manet. It is particularly helpful for comparing the social settings of Luncheon of the Boating Party and The Spanish Ballet without treating their very different painted surfaces as interchangeable.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12